



Outlook

Request for retrospective ethical review: timing departure in study submitted 13 May 2026

From Dietmar Janetzko <Dietmar.Janetzko@ncirl.ie>**Date** Sun 05/07/2026 20:20**To** NCI Research Ethics Sub Committee <ResearchEthicsSubCommittee@ncirl.ie>**Cc** Horacio Gonzalez-Velez <Horacio.Gonzalez-Velez@ncirl.ie>

Dear REC Chair,

I am writing to notify the Research Ethics Committee of a procedural departure in a study whose application was submitted on 13 May 2026, titled *Human rater validation of an LLM judged tutoring dialogue rubric*.

At the time of writing this email, we have not yet received a decision on that application from NCI's Research Ethics Committee. Therefore, on 1 and 3 July 2026 we proceeded with the recruitment and conducted the study. This was done under the pressure of a resubmission deadline for a manuscript conditionally accepted for publication by the *International Journal of AI in Education (IJAIED)* and on our assessment that the study posed minimal risk. I recognise that this assessment was the Committee's to make, not mine, and that proceeding before a decision was a departure from procedure for which I take responsibility. The departure is disclosed in the manuscript's Ethical Considerations and Declarations sections.

In a nutshell, participants read fully AI-generated student–teacher dialogues on secondary-school maths and rated each one on two dimensions. The first was how much the student appeared to learn across the dialogue. The second was how much the teacher demanded reasoning rather than supplying answers.

Via *prolific.com* we recruited 67 adult crowdworkers for this purpose adhering to the ethical guidelines of this platform, which demands, e.g., full transparency on whether the materials were AI-generated. Each participant was given a randomly generated 8-character code. We did not record names, email addresses, IP addresses, or Prolific IDs in the research data. Participants were paid at Prolific's standard fair-pay hourly rate and based on the time spent for this task. Recruitment took place in two waves, on 1 and 3 July 2026, using the same Prolific study ID. Unless the editors of the IJAIED requests it, no further data collection will take place, and no new use will be made of the collected ratings, until the Committee has reached a decision.

The full study protocol, sampling frame, sentinel dialogues, deployed instrument HTML, and cumulative rating dataset are available on the Open Science Framework at <https://osf.io/ae8gm/>, with a timestamp that predates this notification. The related manuscript is Janetzko and González-Vélez, *Dovetailing Case Based Reasoning and Large Language Models to Compare Teaching Strategies: A Multi Turn Dialogue Framework using the EEDI Dataset*, currently under revision at the International Journal of Artificial Intelligence in Education.

I am writing to:

- formally notify the Committee of the timing departure;
- request retrospective review of the study; and
- confirm that I am available to provide any further documentation you may need.

If any concerns arise during retrospective review, I will address them promptly and, if the Committee thinks it appropriate, pause dissemination of the manuscript while that is being resolved.

I would appreciate an acknowledgement of receipt when convenient, so the notification can be dated in the manuscript audit trail.

Yours sincerely,
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